

TIRUPATI LADDU CRISIS: PROCUREMENT FRAUD AND GOVERNANCE FAILURE IN TTD

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Research Interests: Tamil Script Systems; Historical Linguistics; Speculative Philology

Abstract

The Tirupati Laddu controversy represents a significant case of procurement failure and institutional governance breakdown within one of India's most prominent religious institutions. This study examines how procurement policies emphasizing cost minimization, combined with weaknesses in oversight mechanisms, created conditions that facilitated supply-chain adulteration and administrative compromise within the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD). Drawing upon investigative reports, judicial developments, and governance literature, the paper analyses the structural vulnerabilities that enabled procurement irregularities to persist. The findings suggest that excessive reliance on lowest-bidder procurement frameworks, coupled with insufficiently protected reporting systems, can undermine institutional integrity and public trust. The study concludes by highlighting the importance of transparent procurement systems, decentralized verification mechanisms, and cooperative-based sourcing models in safeguarding public institutions against institutional capture.

Keywords: Tirupati Laddu, TTD, procurement fraud, governance failure, institutional capture, public accountability, food adulteration.

1. Introduction

Public institutions derive legitimacy from public trust. When procurement systems responsible for essential goods become compromised, the resulting damage extends beyond financial losses and directly affects institutional credibility and public confidence (OECD, 2016). The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanam (TTD), one of the world's largest religious institutions, became the focus of national attention following allegations about the quality and sourcing of ghee used in preparing the sacred Tirupati Laddu (Raghavendra, 2024).

The controversy attracted widespread concern because the Tirupati Laddu is not merely a food product, but a sacred offering distributed to millions of devotees annually. Consequently, any compromise in its production process carries both administrative and symbolic implications. This paper examines the procurement failures that enabled the controversy, the mechanisms through which institutional controls were allegedly bypassed, and the governance reforms introduced in response. By situating the case within broader theories of institutional capture and procurement integrity, the study seeks to draw lessons applicable to public administration and autonomous institutions worldwide.

2. Case Background

The institutional compromise of the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanam procurement network illustrates a significant example of procurement vulnerability within an autonomous religious body. While discussions of corruption often focus on direct financial embezzlement or accounting fraud, investigations into the Tirupati Laddu controversy revealed concerns regarding the integrity of food-quality standards and procurement oversight.

According to investigative reports, private dairy suppliers exploited administrative weaknesses in the procurement framework to circumvent quality-control mechanisms designed to ensure the purity of ghee supplied to the institution (The New Indian Express, 2024). Rather than representing a simple logistical failure, the controversy exposed vulnerabilities within a procurement model increasingly driven by cost minimisation.

Historically, farmer-owned cooperatives such as the Karnataka Milk Federation (KMF) and its Nandini brand supplied pure cow ghee to the institution under transparent pricing structures intended to support rural dairy communities (Raghavan, 2026). However, the adoption of strict lowest-bidder procurement policies significantly altered the competitive environment. As procurement decisions increasingly prioritised price over quality assurance, private suppliers were able to secure contracts by submitting bids below prevailing market production costs. This shift created incentives for cost recovery through questionable supply chain practices and opened opportunities to exploit procurement controls.

3. Anatomy of the Procurement Fraud

The most damaging aspect of the controversy was not merely the alleged presence of adulterated products, but the reported failure of quality-assurance mechanisms intended to protect institutional integrity. In a properly functioning procurement system, laboratory reports serve as independent gatekeepers that determine whether supplied materials satisfy established quality thresholds.

Forensic and administrative tracking finalised by state bodies revealed a deeply entrenched structural crisis involving the systematic compromise of chemical and biological supply thresholds (South First Desk, 2026). Independent laboratory analyses from the Central Food Technological Research Institute (CFTRI) as early as August 2022 confirmed the presence of plant-derived oils through beta-Sitosterol verification (The New Indian Express, 2026). However, these findings did not result in corrective action. Instead, the administrative leadership bypassed mandatory Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) testing requirements, allowing over 70 lakh kilograms of untested ghee to flood the supply chain from non-compliant private firms (The New Indian Express, 2026).

Investigators alleged that adverse quality-control information was intercepted, delayed, or suppressed before reaching external regulatory eyes (South First Desk, 2026). This was not isolated misconduct; rather, the federal Enforcement Directorate (ED) uncovered an organized money laundering apparatus where over 45 crore rupees in proceeds of crime—generated by private dairies supplying adulterated fat—were layered and hidden across a complex web of shell companies and high-value real estate investments (The Times of India, 2026). The controversy explicitly illustrates what governance scholars describe as institutional capture, a condition in which oversight structures intended to regulate conduct become completely subverted by the very economic actors they are meant to monitor (Rose-Ackerman & Palifka, 2016).

4. Impact on Institutional Trust and Governance

The exposure of procurement irregularities had immediate consequences for public confidence in the institution. Because the Tirupati Laddu holds profound religious significance for millions of devotees, the allegations generated widespread concern regarding both administrative accountability and product integrity. Public discourse rapidly expanded beyond questions of food quality to broader concerns regarding governance, oversight, and institutional responsibility (Rangarajan, 2026).

The controversy also highlighted the limitations of relying solely on internal verification systems. Once confidence in these mechanisms was undermined, public demands for independent oversight intensified. The legal validity of these parallel tracks was reinforced when the Supreme Court ruled that external administrative inquiries into systemic lapses did not interfere with ongoing criminal prosecution, illustrating the gravity of multi-layered institutional failure (The Hindu, 2026).

Operationally, the institution was compelled to review procurement arrangements, strengthen quality-assurance procedures, and implement enhanced verification measures. The case demonstrated that reputational damage can often exceed the direct financial costs associated with procurement failures. More broadly, the incident became a national example of how governance failures within highly respected institutions can have consequences that extend far beyond the immediate administrative environment.

5. Governance Failures and Root Causes

5.1 Lowest-Bidder Procurement Risk

The adoption of a strict lowest-bidder (L1) procurement framework introduced significant structural vulnerabilities. The policy allowed suppliers to engage in steep price cuts of up to 207 rupees per kilogram below standard market rates, making it impossible for premium, transparent cooperatives to compete (The New Indian Express, 2026). The OECD (2016) notes that procurement systems focused exclusively on cost reduction create severe incentives for quality deterioration and opportunistic food fraud.

5.2 Weak Internal Controls and Lab Suppression

The controversy exposed excessive dependence on a compromised internal verification loop. The TTD Food and Water laboratory lacked the advanced physical instrumentation required for real-time adulteration tracking, and upgrades were delayed for nearly three years despite repeated internal warnings (South First Desk, 2026). This administrative vulnerability allowed high-level gatekeepers to hide critical non-compliance data (Transparency International, 2021).

5.3 Institutional Capture

The allegations reflected classic institutional capture. Private corporations conspired with internal administrative layers to bypass safety rules, ensuring that analytical failures were buried in internal filing cabinets while corporate actors preserved their lucrative contracts (Rose-Ackerman & Palifka, 2016).

5.4 Accountability Failure

Effective accountability requires absolute system redundancy. The procurement system collapsed because critical FSSAI testing rules were actively modified or discarded through localised executive orders, completely removing the checks and balances mandated by public interest (World Bank, 2020).

6. Reform Measures and Governance Responses

Following the exposure of the controversy, significant reforms were introduced to restore confidence in procurement operations. One of the most important changes involved strengthening the integrity of laboratory reporting systems. Greater emphasis was placed on digital recordkeeping, automated monitoring, and independent verification frameworks designed to reduce opportunities for manual interference.

The institution also reconsidered supplier selection criteria. Rather than relying exclusively upon cost-based tendering, procurement policies scrapped the rigid L1 system in favor of a quality-cum-cost-based selection process. Additionally, procurement reforms strengthened the role of cooperative suppliers. Following the controversy, state-backed entities like the Bengaluru District Cooperative Milk Producers' Societies Union Limited (BAMUL) and KMF assumed a dominant 62% share in the supply ecosystem, ensuring price stability without compromising biological purity (The Hawk, 2026; Raghavan, 2026).

7. Lessons for Public Administration

The Tirupati Laddu controversy offers several critical lessons for public institutions:

- **Balance Cost and Quality:** Procurement frameworks managing sensitive public consumables must never isolate price as the sole variable; quality parameters must dictate absolute entry barriers (OECD, 2016).
- **Immutable Lab Redundancy:** Quality assurance data must be fed into decentralized, unalterable digital systems so that field-level outputs cannot be delayed or suppressed by administrative gatekeepers.
- **Decentralised Verification:** Institutional resilience relies on separating the procurement board from the auditing board to block cartels from executing total institutional capture (Rose-Ackerman & Palifka, 2016).
- **Proactive Transparency:** Public audits and real-time item sourcing validation should be embedded as a permanent feature of autonomous public boards rather than deployed as damage control.

8. Conclusion

The Tirupati Laddu crisis demonstrates how procurement vulnerabilities, administrative weaknesses, and inadequate oversight can combine to undermine institutional credibility. While the controversy centred on allegations concerning ghee adulteration, its broader significance lies in the governance failures that allowed structural irregularities to persist within a highly trusted public institution.

The case highlights the necessity of procurement frameworks that prioritise both efficiency and integrity. Sustainable governance cannot rely solely upon technological monitoring systems or formal regulations. It requires transparent processes, independent verification mechanisms, and accountability structures resistant to manipulation. Ultimately, the lessons emerging from the controversy extend beyond a single institution and provide valuable insights for governments, autonomous bodies, and public organisations seeking to strengthen procurement governance and preserve public trust.

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THE CERAMIC CANVAS: TRACING THE EPIGRAPHIC AND SOCIOLINGUISTIC EVOLUTION OF THE TAMIL SCRIPT

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Abstract

This paper examines the evolutionary trajectory of southern Indian writing systems from their proto-historical origins to their modern standardized forms. By analyzing the transition from non-phonetic Kuriyeedu (graffiti symbols) to the highly specialized allophonic orthography of Tamizhi (Tamil-Brahmi), the study explores a long-term continuum of literacy and symbolic communication in peninsular India. Particular attention is given to structural adaptations that emerged across Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana in response to linguistic, material, and administrative pressures. The paper further investigates the impact of Grantha, Manipravalam, and regional political developments on script diversification, including the emergence of Malayalam and the Kannada-Telugu script continuum. Finally, the study demonstrates how ancient practices of symbolic identification continue to find parallels in contemporary domestic labelling and organizational systems.

Keywords: Tamizhi, Kuriyeedu, Tamil-Brahmi, Indus Valley Civilisation, Bhattiprolu, Kadamba Script, Grantha, Script Evolution, Dravidian Languages.

1. Introduction

The evolution of writing systems in southern India has often been interpreted through models that emphasise derivation from northern Brahmi traditions. While the influence of Brahmi remains an important component of South Asian epigraphy, archaeological discoveries and linguistic research increasingly suggest that the southern peninsula possessed its own complex traditions of symbolic communication and script adaptation (Mahadevan, 2014; Salomon, 1998).

This study examines the development of southern writing systems from early graffiti symbols to historically attested alphabets. By exploring the relationship between Kuriyeedu, Tamizhi, Bhattiprolu, Kadamba, Grantha, and later regional scripts, the paper argues that orthographic evolution in southern India was shaped not only by linguistic requirements but also by geography, political authority, and writing materials. The result was not a single linear tradition but a network of related script cultures that adapted to distinct regional circumstances (Krishnamurti, 2003).

2. Discussion

2.1 The Silent Origins: Kuriyeedu and the Indus Connection

Prior to the emergence of formal phonetic alphabets, systems of visual identification played an important role in communication, ownership marking, and symbolic representation. In southern India, these markings are commonly referred to as Kuriyeedu or graffiti symbols. Archaeological excavations at sites such as Keezhadi, Thulukarpatti, and Kodumanal have revealed numerous examples engraved on pottery fragments, cave surfaces, and other material objects (Rajan & Sivananthan, 2024).

Several researchers have observed notable morphological correspondences between recurring Kuriyeedu motifs and signs documented within the Indus script corpus (Balakrishnan, 2021; Rajan & Sivananthan, 2024). While the nature of this relationship remains debated and no scholarly consensus exists regarding direct continuity, these similarities have generated significant interest in discussions concerning long-term cultural transmission between northwestern and southern regions of the subcontinent.

Following the decline of urban centers associated with the Indus Valley Civilization during the second millennium BCE, various models propose the movement of populations, cultural practices, and symbolic traditions into other regions of South Asia (Balakrishnan, 2021). Within this framework, Kuriyeedu may be understood as part of a broader visual tradition that persisted independently of later phonetic writing systems.

The functional role of these symbols extended beyond symbolism alone. In domestic contexts, markings served as identifiers for ownership and organization. Comparable practices continue today through the labelling of household items, educational materials, and storage containers. Although separated by millennia, both systems reflect similar cognitive approaches to classification and material organization.

2.2 The Linguistic Engineering of Tamizhi

As spoken Tamil developed greater phonological complexity, non-phonetic symbols became insufficient for representing linguistic information. This transition facilitated the emergence of Tamizhi, commonly referred to in modern scholarship as Tamil-Brahmi (Mahadevan, 2014).

Although often classified as a southern adaptation of Brahmi, Tamizhi exhibits significant structural modifications tailored to the phonological requirements of Old Tamil. Unlike northern Brahmi traditions, which maintained separate characters for aspirated and voiced consonants, Tamizhi adopted an allophonic orthographic framework in which pronunciation was largely determined by phonological context rather than character inventory (Mahadevan, 2014; Krishnamurti, 2003).

This system allowed a relatively compact alphabet to represent a wide range of phonetic realisations. Furthermore, scholars developed unique graphemes to represent sounds characteristic of Muthozhi languages, including ழ (Zha), ற (Ra), and ன (Na), which lacked direct equivalents in northern writing systems (Mahadevan, 2014).

The visual appearance of Tamizhi also reflected its material environment. Characters were generally angular and linear, making them suitable for inscription on stone surfaces and pottery.

2.3 Epigraphic Divergence in the Greater Deccan

While Tamil-speaking regions preserved a largely allophonic orthographic framework, different trajectories emerged across the Deccan plateau. In modern Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, script development occurred within multilingual environments characterised by interactions among Dravidian languages, Prakriti, and later Sanskrit traditions (Salomon, 1998).

One of the earliest examples of regional adaptation is the Bhattiprolu script of Andhra Pradesh. Dating from approximately the third to first centuries BCE, this writing system introduced structural modifications that distinguished it from Ashokan Brahmi and improved its suitability for local linguistic requirements (Bühler, 1894; Sarma, 1992).

In Karnataka, script development accelerated under the Kadamba dynasty, whose inscriptions demonstrate the emergence of what is often termed the Kadamba script or Pre-Old-Kannada (Salomon, 1998). Over subsequent centuries, the script evolved through the administrative traditions of the Chalukyas and Rashtrakutas, eventually forming the basis of the shared Kannada-Telugu script continuum.

By approximately the tenth century CE, this common script tradition gradually diverged into the distinct modern scripts associated with Kannada and Telugu. Despite later differentiation, both systems retain evidence of their shared historical foundations (Krishnamurti, 2003).

2.4 Grantha, Manipravalam, and Regional Divergence

The introduction of Sanskrit into administrative, religious, and literary domains created new orthographic challenges throughout southern India. To accommodate Sanskrit phonology, scribes increasingly employed the Grantha script, which possessed the expanded consonantal inventory necessary for representing aspirated sounds absent from native Dravidian systems (Salomon, 1998).

This interaction encouraged the development of Manipravalam, a hybrid literary tradition combining Sanskrit lexical items with local grammatical structures. Palm-leaf manuscripts frequently display alternating script usage, reflecting the coexistence of multiple linguistic traditions within the same textual environment.

Regional responses to this development differed significantly. In Kerala, sustained interaction between Grantha and Vatteluttu contributed to the gradual emergence of the Malayalam script. In Tamil Nadu, however, scribes largely preserved the existing orthographic framework while incorporating a limited set of Grantha-derived characters to represent external loanwords (Mahadevan, 2014).

These divergent responses illustrate how script evolution was shaped not only by language contact but also by regional political and cultural preferences.

2.5 Material Evolution into Modern Tamil Script

Changes in writing materials significantly influenced orthographic design. As palm-leaf manuscripts became the dominant medium for literary production, angular strokes posed practical challenges because they could damage the writing surface.

To accommodate this material constraint, scribes increasingly adopted curved and rounded forms that reduced the likelihood of tearing palm leaves. This process contributed to the development of Vatteluttu and other rounded writing traditions (Mahadevan, 2014).

Subsequent developments associated with printing technologies, educational standardisation, and digital typography further transformed these historical forms into the modern Tamil script used today. Despite these changes, many structural features of the earlier writing traditions remain recognizable within contemporary orthography.

3. Conclusion

The history of southern Indian writing systems demonstrates that script evolution is inseparable from linguistic structure, material technology, and political context. From the symbolic markings of Kuriyeedu to the allophonic precision of Tamizhi and the regional diversification of Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, each stage reflects an adaptive response to changing communicative needs.

Rather than representing passive borrowings from external traditions, southern scripts emerged through continuous processes of modification, innovation, and regional specialization. The preservation of distinctive Dravidian phonological features, alongside adaptations to new administrative and literary environments, underscores the dynamic nature of orthographic development.

Ultimately, the southern script traditions reveal how writing systems function not merely as tools of communication but as enduring records of cultural adaptation and historical continuity.

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